resolve and the American response. In time, the China Threat theory would gain currency. Nor was China able to stop what it had feared, which is a growing convergence between India and the United States, which was to blossom under President George W. Bush. And, most importantly, it revived the issue of strategic 'parity' between India and China. Immediately after the tests, some Western academics opined that India could not achieve a core objective, that of dissuading the Chinese from supporting the Pakistan nuclear programme. This was never in fact an objective. India had hoped that the full normalization of relations following the visit of Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi to China in December 1988 might lead the Chinese to re-consider their nuclear assistance to Pakistan, but this did not happen. Hence, the Indian side had no illusions about the nature of the Sino-Pak nuclear alliance by the time of India's nuclear tests. India would continue to raise this subject in order to keep reminding the Chinese about an inconvenient truth, namely that they were a factor in the global proliferation of nuclear weapons. This is a fact that the Chinese preferred the world forget.

What are the lessons to be drawn from the Chinese behaviour? One important lesson is the outsized importance that China attaches to its image. This is so because the Chinese State and the Communist Party of China are one and the same. The Chinese Communist Party derives its own legitimacy in part from the image it portrays to its people. While the authoritarian system is conducive to image-shaping within China, the international environment is more difficult for China to control because it is open and democratic. Hence, China expends substantial diplomatic capital in image-building abroad. This includes grand spectacles like the 2008 Beijing Olympic Games and the 2016 G-20 Summit in Hangzhou as well as projections of China as a benign and reasonable power